

# Qualitative Research Designs

120 minutes · 6 self-check questions

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*The major qualitative traditions, the data collection methods attached to each, and how rigour is established when the aim is understanding rather than measurement.*

## Learning objectives

- Distinguish phenomenology, grounded theory, ethnography, case study and narrative inquiry
- Match a qualitative tradition to a research question
- Design an interview guide and a focus group schedule
- Explain sampling logic in qualitative work and the concept of information power
- Apply the criteria of trustworthiness and explain reflexivity
- Recognise when a qualitative design is the right answer and when it is an evasion

## The major traditions

- Phenomenology — describes the lived experience of a phenomenon; asks what it is like to live through this; small purposive samples, in-depth interviews
- Grounded theory — builds theory from data through constant comparison and theoretical sampling; data collection and analysis proceed together
- Ethnography — describes culture and practice through prolonged immersion and participant observation; fieldnotes are primary data
- Case study — examines a bounded system in depth using multiple data sources; may be single or multiple case, and is strong for "how" and "why" questions
- Narrative inquiry — treats the story itself as the unit of analysis, attending to how people construct accounts of their lives
- Descriptive qualitative — a legitimate, atheoretical option when the aim is a straightforward account of views and experiences

### IN PRACTICE

*Choosing a tradition commits you to its sampling, data collection and analysis. Claiming grounded theory and then running six interviews with thematic analysis is a mismatch examiners look for specifically.*

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## Data collection

- In-depth interviews — best for sensitive topics and individual experience; typically 45-90 minutes
- Focus groups — 6-10 participants; strong for surfacing shared norms and disagreement; poor for sensitive or stigmatised topics
- Participant and non-participant observation — captures what people do rather than what they say they do
- Document analysis — policies, records, media; unobtrusive and useful for institutional questions
- Photovoice and participatory methods — shift some control to participants and suit community-based work
- Triangulation combines sources or methods so that a finding does not rest on one type of evidence

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## Interview guides

- Structure the guide in funnels: open broadly, then probe specifics, then close
- Ask open questions — "tell me about...", "walk me through...", "what was that like?"
- Avoid leading questions, double-barrelled questions and jargon
- Plan probes in advance: "can you say more?", "what happened next?", "can you give an example?"
- Six to ten main questions is usually enough for a 60-minute interview
- Pilot the guide and expect to revise it — this is a strength, not a failure
- In focus groups, plan how you will manage a dominant speaker and draw out quiet participants

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## Sampling and sample size

- Sampling is purposive: participants are chosen because they can illuminate the question, not to represent a population statistically
- Maximum variation sampling seeks diversity; homogeneous sampling seeks depth within a defined group
- Theoretical sampling, specific to grounded theory, selects the next participant based on what the emerging analysis requires
- Snowball sampling reaches hidden populations but tends to stay within one network
- Saturation is the point where new data generate no new codes or themes
- Information power is the more defensible modern concept: narrow aim, dense sample specificity, strong theory and strong dialogue all reduce the number needed
- Typical ranges: 6-12 for a homogeneous phenomenological study, 20-30 for grounded theory, but justify rather than cite a number

#### IN PRACTICE

*Declaring saturation after a fixed number of interviews planned in advance is not saturation. Saturation is something you observe during analysis and must be able to evidence.*

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## Rigour and reflexivity

- Credibility — do the findings represent the participants' reality? Supported by member checking, triangulation and prolonged engagement
- Transferability — could findings apply elsewhere? Supported by thick description of context so readers can judge
- Dependability — would the process be consistent if repeated? Supported by an audit trail
- Confirmability — do findings follow from the data rather than the researcher's preferences? Supported by memos and reflexive notes
- Reflexivity means recording your own position — profession, assumptions, relationship to participants — and how it shaped the work
- Generalisability in the statistical sense is not the aim, and apologising for its absence misunderstands the design



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## Worked examples

### The same topic in four qualitative traditions

*The topic is the experience of women living with obstetric fistula. Four traditions would produce four genuinely different studies.*

1. Phenomenology: what is it like to live with fistula? 8-12 in-depth interviews, focused on lived experience.
2. Grounded theory: how do women come to seek or avoid repair? Theoretical sampling, constant comparison, ending in a theory of care-seeking.
3. Ethnography: how does the community treat these women? Months of observation in a village, fieldnotes as primary data.
4. Case study: how did one repair programme work? Interviews, records, observation and policy documents on a single bounded programme.
5. Each demands its own sampling, data collection and analysis. You cannot claim one and execute another.

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#### THE POINT

Name your tradition and then live by its rules. "Grounded theory" followed by six interviews and a thematic analysis is the mismatch examiners look for first.

### Rewriting an interview guide that will not work

*A student's first interview guide opens with: "Don't you agree that the long waiting times and rude staff are the main problems at this clinic?"*

1. It is leading — it supplies the answer the interviewer expects.
2. It is double-barrelled — waiting times and staff attitude are two different things.
3. It is closed — it can be answered "yes", ending the topic.
4. It opens on a complaint, before any rapport exists, which shapes everything that follows.
5. Rewrite: "Tell me about the last time you came to this clinic. Walk me through the day." Then probe: "What was the waiting like?", "How did you find the staff?"

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#### THE POINT

Open wide, then narrow with probes. Pilot the guide on two people — you will change it, and that is a sign the piloting worked, not that the guide was bad.

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## Key terms

### Purposive sampling

Selecting participants deliberately for their capacity to inform the research question.

### Saturation

The point at which further data collection yields no new codes, categories or themes.

### Information power

The principle that the richer and more specific the sample and aim, the fewer participants are needed.

### Reflexivity

Systematic attention to how the researcher shapes and is shaped by the research.

### Thick description

Detailed account of context and meaning sufficient for a reader to judge transferability.

### Triangulation

Using multiple sources, methods or investigators to strengthen confidence in a finding.

### Audit trail

A documented record of decisions taken through the research, allowing the process to be followed.

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## Activity

Draft a six-question interview guide for your own topic. Swap with a partner, who must flag every leading, closed or double-barrelled question and rewrite one of them. Then role-play the first two questions and note where the guide fails in practice.

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## Further reading

- **Braun & Clarke — Successful Qualitative Research** — Practical, opinionated and reliable throughout.
- **Malterud, Siersma & Guassora (2016) — "Sample Size in Qualitative Interview Studies"** — The information power concept; short and worth reading in full.
- **Lincoln & Guba — Naturalistic Inquiry** — The origin of the trustworthiness criteria.
- **Creswell & Poth — Qualitative Inquiry and Research Design** — Compares the five traditions side by side.

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## Self-check questions

1. A researcher wants to build a theory of how nurses develop resilience, collecting and analysing data simultaneously and choosing later participants based on emerging categories. This is:
  - a. Phenomenology
  - b. Grounded theory
  - c. Ethnography
  - d. Narrative inquiry
2. Focus groups are a poor choice for which topic?
  - a. Community attitudes to a new clinic
  - b. Individual experiences of intimate partner violence
  - c. Shared norms about handwashing
  - d. Reactions to a proposed health policy
3. "Don't you think the long waiting times are the main problem at the clinic?" is flawed because it is:
  - a. Too open
  - b. Leading, and also closed
  - c. Double-barrelled only
  - d. Appropriately probing
4. A student writes: "Saturation was achieved as 15 interviews had been planned." This is unsatisfactory because:
  - a. Fifteen interviews is too few
  - b. Saturation is observed during analysis, not decided by a prior plan
  - c. Saturation applies only to grounded theory
  - d. Saturation requires at least 30 participants
5. Providing detailed description of setting, participants and context primarily supports which criterion?
  - a. Credibility
  - b. Transferability
  - c. Dependability
  - d. Confirmability
6. A qualitative thesis states: "A limitation is that findings cannot be generalised to the wider population." The best response is that this:
  - a. Is an appropriate limitation to acknowledge

- b. Misapplies a quantitative criterion; transferability is the relevant concept
  - c. Means the sample size was too small
  - d. Requires a statistical power calculation
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## Answers

1. **b.** Simultaneous collection and analysis, constant comparison and theoretical sampling are the defining features of grounded theory, whose explicit aim is to generate theory.
  2. **b.** Stigmatised or sensitive individual experiences are unlikely to be disclosed in front of peers, and disclosure could put participants at risk. In-depth individual interviews are appropriate here.
  3. **b.** It supplies the answer and invites agreement, and it can be answered yes or no. "What is it like attending this clinic?" opens the topic without directing the response.
  4. **b.** Saturation is an empirical observation that new data are producing no new codes. Announcing it because a planned number was reached inverts the logic and cannot be evidenced.
  5. **b.** Thick description lets readers judge whether findings might apply in their own setting, which is how transferability works — the reader makes the judgement, not the researcher.
  6. **b.** Statistical generalisation was never the aim of the design. Framing its absence as a limitation suggests the researcher has not understood the logic of the method they used.
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